What the font shorthand sets

small-caps: the lowercase letters drawn as small capitals, the first letter of each word a full-size capital.

Small capitals, not full capitals

The box sets line-height: 3. The shorthand names no line height, so these lines are closely spaced.

This paragraph is long enough to wrap onto more than one line, which shows how far apart the lines are drawn once the shorthand has reset the line height.

For comparison, the same box with font-size: 12pt in place of the shorthand: widely spaced lines.

This paragraph is long enough to wrap onto more than one line, which shows

how far apart the lines are drawn with the line height the box sets.

The box sets line-height: 3. The shorthand gives 12pt/2, so these lines are twice the font size apart.

This paragraph is long enough to wrap onto more than one line, which shows

how far apart the lines are drawn with the line height the shorthand gives.

The box sets italic, bold and small-caps. The first line keeps them; the second, set with the shorthand, is upright, regular-weight lowercase.

Italic bold small caps from the box
upright regular lowercase from the shorthand

The same on an inline element: only the middle words are upright, regular-weight lowercase.

Italic bold small caps, upright regular lowercase, ***italic bold small caps***

font: caption names a system font, which mPDF has none of, so it is dropped: italic 14pt serif from the rule before it.

Italic 14pt serif